obtained in Shandong. It was also hoped that under President Wilson, who declared a more moral and enlightened foreign policy, the continuing Japanese pressures on China would be resisted. In 1915, Japan had presented the so-called ‘Twenty-one Demands’ on China, claiming greatly expanded concessions in Manchuria, and additionally in Inner Mongolia. However, the Chinese delegation was disappointed when the great powers gathered at Vienna decided to allow Japan to succeed to Germany’s rights and privileges in Shandong, in effect accepting Japan as having a sphere of influence over China.

There was a very negative popular reaction to this throughout China, but particularly in Beijing. The demonstrations in the capital were led by students from educational institutions across the city. This came to be known as the May Fourth Movement and had very strong nationalist overtones. The demonstrations spread to other cities too. While anti-Japanese sentiment grew significantly after this, the West was also condemned as being hypocritical and without scruples. The need for China to be strong was a common concern, but there were different views on how this was to be achieved.

It was in this milieu that the Bolshevik Revolution in Russia came to exercise increasing influence. The setting up of the Leninist state in Moscow based on Marxist principles became a new model to be studied and emulated. That Moscow in the initial days of the Bolshevik government renounced its special privileges in China contrasted with the attitude towards China of the predatory West, swearing by enlightened and democratic ideals but displaying the opposite in their practical behaviour.

The CPC was established in 1921 by a small group of left-wing intellectuals in Shanghai, which included Mao Zedong. With the help of the Comintern, it began to expand its influence throughout China, but its triumph would come later. The model of the Soviet–Leninist state found fertile ground to grow in China. It was modern but not tainted by the West. Its core was a highly centralized state, which was considered more aligned to China’s historical experience as a centralized empire. Its egalitarian pretensions appealed to a newly emerging elite which was critical of the